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Faculty Name – Radhika Gokani
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4.1 Network Layer

The Network Layer is an essential part of the OSI (Open Systems Interconnection) model. It's the third layer, positioned between the Data Link Layer (Layer 2) and the Transport Layer (Layer 4).

Functions of the Network Layer

- **Routing:** Determines the optimal path for data to travel from the source to the destination. Routers operate at this layer.
- **Logical Addressing:** Assigns IP addresses to devices, ensuring each device can be uniquely identified on the network. This is crucial for data delivery to the correct destination.
- **Packet Forwarding:** Moves packets from one network segment to another, ensuring they reach their final destination.
- **Fragmentation and Reassembly:** Breaks down large packets into smaller fragments to pass through networks with smaller maximum transmission units (MTUs) and reassembles them at the destination.

Concepts

- **IP Addressing:** The Internet Protocol (IP) is used for addressing and routing packets. IPv4 (32-bit addresses) and IPv6 (128-bit addresses) are the most common protocols.
- **Routing Algorithms:** Used to determine the best path for data to travel across a network. Examples include OSPF (Open Shortest Path First) and BGP (Border Gateway Protocol).
- **Packet Switching:** Involves breaking down data into packets that are transmitted over various routes and reassembled at the destination.

Importance of the Network Layer

- **Scalability:** Allows the network to grow and support more devices without significant changes to the underlying infrastructure.
- **Interconnectivity:** Ensures different network types (LAN, WAN, MAN) can connect and communicate efficiently.
- **Efficiency:** Optimizes the use of network resources through routing and addressing.

4.1 Introduction to forwarding and routing

Forwarding and routing are fundamental functions of the network layer in computer networking.

Forwarding

Forwarding refers to the process of transferring a packet from an incoming interface to the appropriate outgoing interface within a single router. Think of it like a mail sorting system within a post office, where the packet is moved to the next hop on its journey toward its final destination.

Tasks in forwarding includes

- **Lookup and Forwarding:** The router examines the packet's destination IP address and consults its forwarding table to determine the next hop.
- **Switching Fabric:** Internal processes move the packet from the input port to the correct output port.
- **Queuing:** If there is congestion, packets may be queued until the outgoing link is available.

Routing

Routing, on the other hand, is the overall process of determining the paths that packets take from source to destination across multiple routers. It's akin to planning the route on a map. Routing involves:

- **Routing Algorithms:** Algorithms like Distance Vector, Link State, and Path Vector calculate the optimal path for packet delivery.
- **Routing Tables:** Routers build and maintain these tables to know where to forward packets. These tables are updated dynamically based on network topology changes.
- **Routing Protocols:** Protocols such as OSPF (Open Shortest Path First), BGP (Border Gateway Protocol), and EIGRP (Enhanced Interior Gateway Routing Protocol) are used to disseminate routing information between routers.

Differences

1. **Scope:** Forwarding is a local activity within a router; routing is a global process involving the entire network.
- 2.

- 3.
4. **Function:** Forwarding deals with moving packets to their next hop, while routing determines the entire path from source to destination.
5. **Process:** Forwarding is implemented in hardware for speed, while routing is often managed by software to allow for complex computations.

By combining these two functions, networks efficiently deliver packets from source to destination even across vast distances and complex topologies.

4.2 Network Service models

Network service models define the characteristics of end-to-end data transport between two points in a network, typically between a sender and a receiver.

- **Circuit-Switched Network:** Establishes a dedicated physical path between sender and receiver for the duration of the connection. Traditional telephone networks are an example.
- **Packet-Switched Network:** Data is divided into packets, which are routed individually over various paths in the network. The Internet is a prime example of a packet-switched network.
- **Message-Switched Network:** Similar to packet switching, but entire messages are routed one hop at a time. Each switch stores the entire message before forwarding it.
- **Virtual Circuit Network:** Combines elements of both circuit and packet switching. A virtual path is established before data transfer, but data is still sent in packets.
- **Datagram Network:** Each packet (datagram) is treated independently, with no pre-established path. Each packet may take a different route to the destination.

4.3 Virtual and Datagram networks

Virtual Networks

Imagine a network diagram with nodes (representing devices) connected by lines (representing paths). In a virtual network, you'd see dedicated paths or circuits between nodes, clearly marked and consistently connecting the same nodes throughout the communication session.

- **Concept:** Similar to how you book a single path on a scenic route, a virtual network reserves a defined path for data packets between sender and receiver. This path, known as a virtual circuit, remains consistent throughout the communication session.
- **Connection-Oriented:** It establishes a connection before any data transfer begins and maintains it until the end.

- **Data Delivery:** Packets arrive in the sequence they were sent, making it reliable for applications like video streaming or VoIP where order and timing are crucial.
- **Examples:** ATM (Asynchronous Transfer Mode), Frame Relay.

Datagram Network

In contrast, a datagram network diagram would show nodes connected by multiple possible paths, with data packets moving independently along various routes. The lines wouldn't indicate a fixed path but rather a flexible network where packets find their way dynamically.

If you need these visuals for a specific purpose, you might want to search for images online using keywords like "Virtual Network diagram" and "Datagram Network diagram."

- **Concept:** This is more like sending letters through a postal service, where each packet of data (datagram) is treated independently and can take any available route to reach the destination.
- **Connectionless:** No fixed path is established; each datagram finds its own route based on the network's current state.
- **Data Delivery:** Packets may arrive out of order, get lost, or duplicate, making it less reliable for applications that require sequence but suitable for emails or web browsing where order is less critical.
- **Examples:** IP (Internet Protocol), UDP (User Datagram Protocol).

In essence, virtual networks provide a steady, consistent path for data, while datagram networks offer flexibility and efficiency in routing. It's like choosing between a dedicated train track for your journey versus a network of highways.

4.4 study of router

Routers are fascinating devices at the heart of modern networking, directing traffic between different networks and ensuring data packets get to their destinations efficiently. Here are a few key points to understand when studying routers:

1. **Functionality:** Routers connect multiple networks together. They determine the best path for data to travel from its source to its destination using routing tables and protocols.
2. **Routing Protocols:** These protocols define how routers communicate with each other. Common examples include:
 - **RIP (Routing Information Protocol):** Simple and commonly used in smaller networks.
 - **OSPF (Open Shortest Path First):** More complex and used in larger, scalable networks.
 - **BGP (Border Gateway Protocol):** Essential for the internet, it manages how packets are routed across different autonomous systems (e.g., ISPs).
3. **Types of Routers:**
 - **Home Routers:** Usually combine a router, switch, and access point in one device, handling internet access in homes.

- **Enterprise Routers:** More powerful and support extensive networks within large organizations.
 - **Core Routers:** Used by service providers to route data across the internet backbone.
4. **Security:** Routers play a crucial role in network security, using firewalls, VPNs, and access control lists (ACLs) to protect data and control access.
 5. **Configuration:** Understanding how to configure a router, often done through a web interface or command-line interface (CLI), is key. This includes setting IP addresses, subnet masks, and default gateways.

4.5 IP protocol and addressing in the Internet

IP protocol and addressing in the Internet

The Internet Protocol (IP) is a key component of the internet, allowing different devices to communicate with each other by assigning unique addresses and directing data packets. Let's take a closer look at how IP protocol and addressing work on the internet:

IP Protocol

IP is responsible for routing and addressing data packets so they can travel across networks. There are two main versions:

1. **IPv4 (Internet Protocol version 4):**
 - **Address Format:** IPv4 addresses are 32-bit numbers, typically represented in decimal as four groups of numbers separated by periods, e.g., 192.168.1.1.
 - **Address Space:** It provides around 4.3 billion unique addresses, which are becoming increasingly scarce.
 - **Use:** Still widely used, despite the limited address space.
2. **IPv6 (Internet Protocol version 6):**
 - **Address Format:** IPv6 addresses are 128-bit numbers, written in hexadecimal and separated by colons, e.g., 2001:0db8:85a3:0000:0000:8a2e:0370:7334.
 - **Address Space:** Offers an enormous number of unique addresses, vastly expanding the available address space.
 - **Use:** Gaining adoption as a solution to IPv4 exhaustion.

IP Addressing

IP addressing is the system used to assign unique identifiers to each device connected to a network. Here are key aspects:

1. **Types of IP Addresses:**
 - **Public IP Addresses:** Assigned by ISPs and are unique across the internet. They allow devices to be accessible from outside their local network.

- **Private IP Addresses:** Used within private networks and not routable on the internet. Typical ranges include 192.168.x.x, 172.16.x.x - 172.31.x.x, and 10.x.x.x.
- 2. **Static vs. Dynamic IP Addresses:**
 - **Static IP Addresses:** Manually configured and do not change. Useful for servers and network devices requiring consistent access.
 - **Dynamic IP Addresses:** Assigned by DHCP servers and can change over time. Commonly used for most client devices like smartphones, laptops, and desktops.

Subnetting

Subnetting divides a larger network into smaller, more manageable segments (subnets), improving organization and efficiency. Each subnet has a unique subnet mask that defines its network and host portions.

Routing

Routers direct data packets from one network to another using routing tables and protocols. They determine the best path for data to travel. Key routing protocols include:

- **RIP (Routing Information Protocol):** Simple and used in smaller networks.
- **OSPF (Open Shortest Path First):** More complex and used in larger networks.
- **BGP (Border Gateway Protocol):** Essential for routing data across the internet's backbone.

NAT (Network Address Translation)

NAT allows multiple devices on a local network to share a single public IP address for accessing the internet. This helps conserve public IP addresses and adds a layer of security by masking internal IP addresses.

4.6 Routing algorithms

Routing algorithms are crucial for determining the most efficient paths for data packets to travel across networks. Here are some key routing algorithms used in networking:

1. Distance Vector Routing Algorithms

These algorithms calculate the best path based on distance, typically measured in hops. Each router shares its knowledge of the entire network with its immediate neighbors.

- **RIP (Routing Information Protocol):** A well-known distance vector protocol. It uses hop count as the metric, with a maximum limit of 15 hops. It's simple but not ideal for large networks due to its limited scalability and slow convergence.

2. Link State Routing Algorithms

These algorithms build a complete map of the network and use it to determine the shortest path. They are more complex and require more resources than distance vector algorithms.

- **OSPF (Open Shortest Path First):** A widely used link state protocol. It uses the Shortest Path First (SPF) algorithm to calculate the shortest path tree. It's highly scalable and suitable for large networks.
- **IS-IS (Intermediate System to Intermediate System):** Similar to OSPF, it's used in larger networks and ISPs. It also uses the SPF algorithm and can handle large amounts of routing information.

3. Path Vector Protocols

These protocols maintain the path information that gets updated dynamically as the path changes.

- **BGP (Border Gateway Protocol):** The core routing protocol of the internet. It maintains paths to different networks and makes routing decisions based on path attributes and policies. BGP ensures that data packets are routed efficiently across the global internet.

4. Hybrid Routing Algorithms

These algorithms combine elements of both distance vector and link state algorithms.

- **EIGRP (Enhanced Interior Gateway Routing Protocol):** Developed by Cisco, it's a hybrid protocol that uses distance vectors and link state metrics. It offers fast convergence and scalability while maintaining simplicity.

Routing Metrics

Routing algorithms use different metrics to determine the best path, such as:

- **Hop Count:** The number of hops a packet takes to reach its destination.
- **Bandwidth:** The available data transfer capacity of a link.
- **Delay:** The time it takes for a packet to travel from the source to the destination.
- **Reliability:** The likelihood that a link will fail or perform poorly.
- **Load:** The amount of traffic on a link or network.

Convergence

Convergence refers to the process of all routers in a network updating their routing tables and agreeing on the optimal paths. Faster convergence is preferred, as it minimizes downtime and routing inconsistencies.

Example Algorithms:

- **Dijkstra's Algorithm:** Used by link state protocols like OSPF and IS-IS to find the shortest path.

- **Bellman-Ford Algorithm:** Used by distance vector protocols like RIP to calculate the shortest path.

4.7 Broadcast and Multicast routing

Broadcast and multicast routing are both methods used in computer networks to distribute information to multiple recipients, but they differ in how they achieve this goal.

Broadcast Routing

- **Scope:** Broadcast routing sends data to all devices within a network or subnet. It's a "one-to-all" communication method.
- **Use Case:** Commonly used in local area networks (LANs) to deliver messages that need to reach all devices, such as ARP (Address Resolution Protocol) requests.
- **Efficiency:** Broadcast can lead to network congestion if used excessively because every device in the network must process the broadcasted packet.

Multicast Routing

- **Scope:** Multicast routing is more efficient than broadcast because it sends data only to a specific group of interested recipients. It's a "one-to-many" communication method.
- **Use Case:** Ideal for streaming media, online gaming, and other applications where data needs to be delivered to multiple recipients simultaneously but not to everyone on the network.
- **Efficiency:** Multicast is more efficient in terms of network resource usage because it reduces unnecessary data transmission.

Here's a simple analogy: imagine you're announcing an event. Broadcasting is like using a loudspeaker to announce it to everyone in the city (even those not interested), while multicasting is like sending invitations only to people who signed up for the event.